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CONGRESS INFIGHTING, HOODA'S OVERCONFIDENCE
and his pandering to the urban areas finally led to his undoing.

KNOWING THAT CORRUPTION WOULD BE A DOUBLE-EDGED
weapon, Chautala focussed on inflation and law and order.

CHAUTALA
(LEFT) HAS
BEATEN THE
ODDS; HOODA
MISSED A
SIMPLE
MAJORITY

Bishnoi, along with Independents, now hold the key to government formation and may even have a say in the selection of the chief minister, who may not be Hooda. The chief minister was also accused of having a regional bias, earmarking most of the development funds to two or three districts while ignoring others. Voters reciprocated, giving the party impressive wins in Rohtak, Jhajjar and Sonapat while those in Jind and Sirsa, for example, rejected the Congress.

But it was Chautala that Hooda had clearly underestimated. The INLD's election campaign, that was strategically started on Devi Lal's birthday, saw well-attended rallies which even surprised the party. The INLD on the other hand did its homework pretty well and capitalised on the loopholes left by

the Congress. First, it was quick to pick the right candidates in most constituencies. The party also highlighted the "regional bias" of the government and made sure the voter was told.

For the first time, the Chautalas made efforts to repair their image and even hired a PR agency, reaching out this time as a much mellowed unit. Tactically the party decided not to attack the Hooda government on fronts where it itself was weak, like corruption. Its campaign was focused on issues such as price rise, "deteriorating" law and order and local issues. The biggest loser in the state is the BJP which won just four seats. The results have shown that the party is dramatically out of sync in the state. The drawing room strategists at its central headquarters, who

unilaterally snapped the party's links with the INLD without even showing the grace to inform Chautala personally must now be wondering about what might have been. The break-up of the alliance means both parties have suffered and most believe that had they been together, it would have been a different story and they would have easily formed the government as in 2000. But there are also those who point to the INLD's impressive show in the Mewat region where Chautala has assiduously cultivated the largely Muslim votebank over the years. With the BJP in tow, that might not have been the case.

The elections have thrown up no clear winner, but those who wrote the many premature obituaries of Chautala have a lot to think about.